

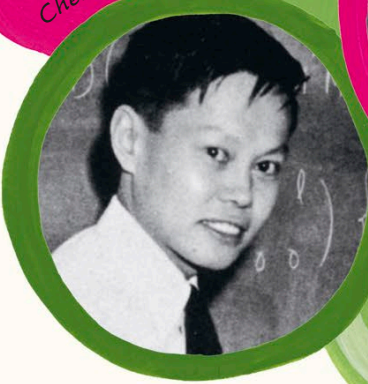
Working together

In the 1950s, Tsung-Dao Lee and Chen Ning Yang asked Chien-Shiung to design an experiment to test their new ideas about beta decay. In 1957, the pair won the Nobel Prize in Physics for their theory—but Chien-Shiung was left out. Afterward, she began to speak out about the unfair treatment of women in science.

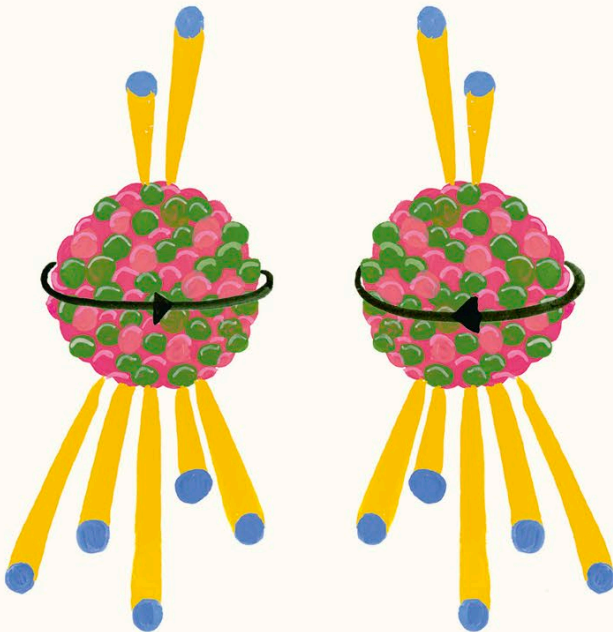
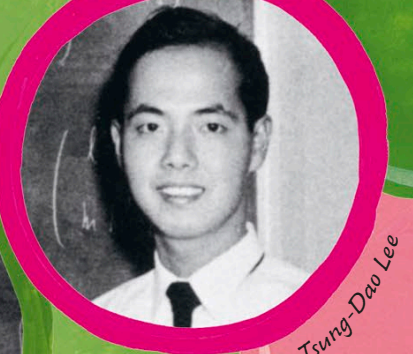
Changing everything

Chien-Shiung became known for her brilliant experiments. For her Nobel-Prize-winning work with Tsung-Dao Lee and Chen Ning Yang, she cooled radioactive cobalt atoms so much that they stopped jiggling around and lined up neatly in a magnetic field.

Chen Ning Yang

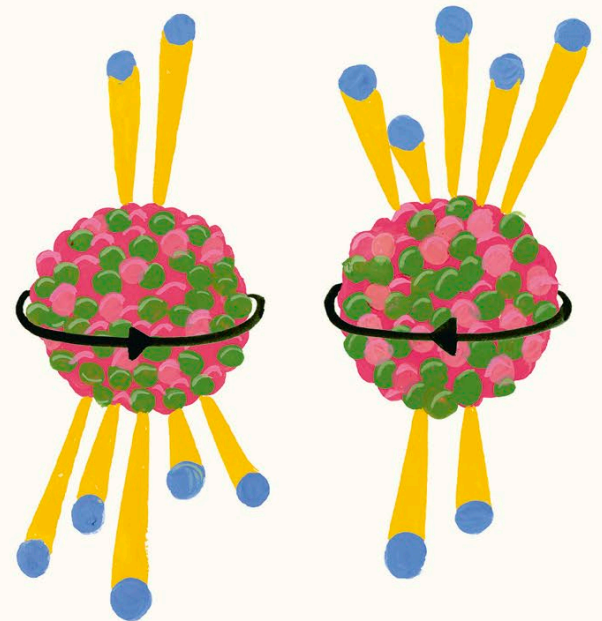


Tsung-Dao Lee



This is what scientists believed would happen before Chien-Shiung's work.

Once the atoms were lined up neatly, Chien-Shiung made them spin in different directions and measured where the electrons from beta decay zoomed out.



This is what actually happened, proving that some of the forces at the very center of atoms are not symmetrical (act the same way in every direction), but left-focused.

The “Wu experiment” changed physics forever. It proved that radioactive forces didn’t obey the laws of symmetry that everything else in the universe seemed to follow. This clue helped unlock all kinds of other mysteries, helping us understand how particles can cling together to form things, such as rocks, metals, and even people!



Chien-Shiung won the National Medal of Science and was the first woman to become president of the American Physical Society.